



Will Social Media Junkies Flock Together with v2.5?

While a Web browser developed specifically to satisfy your social networking needs does sound exciting, will Flock 2.5, the latest browser developed with Firefox's engine at the core, be able to make the cut? Let's dive in and check how deep the water might be!

Flock 2.5 is an open source browser, scheduled around the Gecko rendering engine that takes off at a good starting point: Mozilla Firefox. While it is built on Mozilla's Firefox codebase, it tends to specialise in providing social networking and Web 2.0 facilities built into its user interface. With the Firefox base, Flock has incorporated new modules and has improved some aspects like graphics (three-dimensional icons) and new features like sharing bookmarks online, an integrated tool for creating and maintaining blogs, etc, while maintaining what made Firefox successful in the first place—extensions, lockout of automatic pop-ups, etc.

What's the hype all about?

Flock is designed to streamline how you interface with social networking sites, RSS and media feeds, and blogs. Because it's built on Firefox 3, its behaviour will seem familiar and it supports most—but not all—Firefox extensions. And yes, the 'awesome bar' is part of the latest version.

The social media add-ons are apparent

from the start, though. The 'My World' tab—set as your home page by default—is devoted to collating your favourite stuff in one single view. It's made up of a series of widgets that you can customise to display content from video and photo sites, RSS feeds, saved searches from Twitter and useful bookmarks.

How is a 'social Web browser' different?

While support from Twitter and Facebook had been present in Flock right from its inception, the browser now allows you to search the Twitter timeline and also keep them in *History* so that you can access them as and when you wish. Now, this is a very nifty feature because it lets you stay on top of trending topics on the micro-blogging network. Another great and useful feature is the automatic shortening of URLs that are shared on Twitter.

For the first time, Flock has integrated Facebook chat within the browser. While the side bar sits pretty, at the left of the browser, you can keep sharing content with your contacts while reading the latest